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How to Choose Citation Examples

Please review the following instructions for choosing which citation examples will be most helpful for your RFE response. These instructions are intended as general guidelines for thinking about what types of citations USCIS is most likely to consider significant, and in our experience are applicable to the vast majority of cases. It's important to realize that this may be very different from what you as a research scientist might consider most important, but that we need to try to think like a USCIS officer since they will be making the decision on your petition.

What types of citations will USCIS consider significant?

In most cases, ***how*** your work was used is more important than ***who*** used your work. USCIS is likely to value citations from other experts in the field who have:

- ***Implemented*** your work in their own research by directly adopting your methods, techniques, processes, or models;
- ***Compared*** your work to their own or that of others in a way that reveals that yours is superior in some way;
- ***Utilized*** your work to develop an improved technology, treatment, or method in the field; or
- ***Verified*** the results of your work by successfully applying it to their own research topic.

Other significant citations can come in the form of ***patents***, ***government or technical reports***, ***clinical trials***, ***field guidelines or recommendations***, or any other similar implementation of your work. USCIS may also place greater weight on citations from ***government institutions*** and ***industry***, particularly if researchers at those institutions have significantly implemented and benefited from your work in some way.

It can also be helpful to consider the frequency and length of the citations to your work. It is unlikely that one sentence that cites not only your work, but also several other papers, is going to be of significant value. However, if a paper cites several of your studies and discusses your work at length, this is more likely to be seen as having significant value to the reviewing officer. This is not necessarily a definitive rule, and it may be the case that a one sentence citation can still be valuable in context, but more thorough discussions of your work can often help indicate which citations are more significant.

How does USCIS value the prestige of the citing author, institution, and journal?

We find that many of our clients wish to highlight citations from well-known authors, prestigious institutions, and highly ranked journals. While we understand that a citation from a respected source in your field might carry significant weight from your perspective, ***USCIS appears to be much more interested in the substantive content of the citation***. An extensive citation indicating substantial implementation of your work from a lesser known researcher is likely to be considered more valuable by USCIS than a citation from a famous individual or a highly ranked university that only brief mentions your work as background information. Similarly, USCIS will probably not be persuaded by citations from papers appearing in prestigious journals. This is because USCIS is evaluating your contributions, not those of the citing authors.

Moreover, emphasizing the prestige of the source of your citations can actually ***harm*** your case. We have seen USCIS compare our clients' credentials against those of other experts in the field to justify an RFE or a denial, so focusing on the prestige of the author, institution, or journal that cited your work could lead to such a harmful comparison in your case. You should therefore keep your focus on the substantive quality of your citations rather than who cited your work or where it was cited. In other words, ***how*** your work was used is much more important than ***who*** cited it.

What types of citations will USCIS place less value on?

Citations that only briefly mention your work in passing are unlikely to be considered particularly significant by USCIS. These types of citations frequently occur in the introduction section of a paper to provide background information on the topic, but don't necessarily show that those researchers actually used, benefited from, or were substantially influenced by your work. As such, these types of citations are not usually the best types of evidence to submit to show the impact of your work. We should also avoid highlighting citations that could be interpreted as discussing your work in a negative way. Citations that outline limitations, drawbacks or weaknesses of your work, or where the authors show that their work surpasses your own in some way, are more likely to hurt your case than help.

Can citations in review articles or books be helpful?

We recommend that you focus first and foremost on citations to your work from original research, as in our experience this is most likely to demonstrate the influence of your work. Citations in review articles, however, can be useful for your case. As with any citation, how they cite your work matters, and you should avoid any that could be interpreted as speaking of your work negatively. Rather, you should look for review articles that explicitly highlight the

importance of your work. You can also consider the reasons that the review article was written. Many review articles state that their purpose is to collect research that is "***the most exciting***," "***the most significant***," or represents "***major recent advances***." If your work is cited by those articles, and especially if they specifically discuss your work in those terms, that can be very helpful. Articles that discuss your work at length or cite several of your studies are also more likely to be good evidence. Citations in books can be similarly helpful to highlight that your work has been chosen by experts in the field as particularly important reference material.

What if I can't find any citations that I think fit these guidelines?

Our goal is to help you sort through your citations to find those that will be most helpful for your RFE response, but we understand that not everyone will be able to find citations that exactly conform to these guidelines. Just because you don't have ideal evidence does not mean that we can't still prepare a strong response. If you can't find any citations that exactly meet these standards, you should still try and identify those that come the closest. Keeping these general guidelines in mind will help you think about what USCIS is most likely to consider significant, and will therefore help us in preparing the best response possible.